TRANSPORTATION

Tesla partly liable in Florida Autopilot trial, jury awards $200M in damages

Sean O'Kane — 11:24 AM PDT · August 1, 2025


IMAGE CREDITS: PEERAPON BOONYAKIAT/SOPA IMAGES/LIGHTROCKET / GETTY IMAGES

A jury in federal court in Miami has found Tesla partly to blame for a fatal 2019 crash that involved the use of the company's Autopilot driver assistance system.

The jury assessed punitive damages only against Tesla, CNBC reported. The punitive fines coupled with a compensatory damages puts the total payments to around $242.5 million. The plaintiff's attorney confirmed to TechCrunch that this is the correct amount.

Neither the driver of the car nor the Autopilot system braked in time to avoid going through an intersection, where the car struck an SUV and killed a pedestrian. The jury assigned the driver two-thirds of the blame, and attributed one-third to Tesla. (The driver was sued separately.)

The verdict comes at the end of a three-week trial over the crash, which killed 20-year-old Naibel Benavides Leon and severely injured her boyfriend Dillon Angulo. The verdict is one of the first major legal decisions about driver assistance technology that has gone against Tesla. The company has previously settled lawsuits involving similar claims about Autopilot.

Brett Schreiber, the lead attorney for the plaintiffs in the case, said in a statement to TechCrunch that Tesla designed Autopilot "only for controlled access highways yet deliberately chose not to restrict drivers from using it elsewhere, alongside Elon Musk telling the world Autopilot drove better than humans."

"Tesla's lies turned our roads into test tracks for their fundamentally flawed technology, putting everyday Americans like Naibel Benavides and Dillon Angulo in harm's way," said Schreiber. "Today's verdict represents justice for Naibel's tragic death and Dillon's lifelong injuries, holding Tesla and Musk accountable for propping up the company's trillion-dollar valuation with self-driving hype at the expense of human lives."

Tesla, in a statement provided to TechCrunch, said it plans to appeal the verdict "given the substantial errors of law and irregularities at trial."

"Today's verdict is wrong and only works to set back automotive safety and jeopardize Tesla's and the entire industry's efforts to develop and implement life-saving technology," the company wrote. "To be clear, no car in 2019, and none today, would have prevented this crash. This was never about Autopilot; it was a fiction concocted by plaintiffs' lawyers blaming the car when the driver — from day one — admitted and accepted responsibility."

Tesla and Musk spent years making claims about Autopilot's capabilities that have led to overconfidence in the driver assistance system, a reality that government officials — and Musk himself — have spoken about for years.

The National Transportation Safety Board (NTSB) came to this determination in 2020 after investigating a 2018 crash where the driver died after hitting a concrete barrier. That driver, Walter Huang, was playing a mobile game while using Autopilot. The NTSB made a number of recommendations following that investigation,

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which Tesla largely ignored, the safety board later claimed.

On a 2018 conference call, Musk said "complacency" with driver assistance systems like Autopilot is a problem.

"They just get too used to it. That tends to be more of an issue. It's not a lack of understanding of what Autopilot can do. It's [drivers] thinking they know more about Autopilot than they do," Musk said at the time.

The trial took place at a time when Tesla is currently in the middle of rolling out the first versions of its long-promised Robotaxi network, starting in Austin, Texas. Those vehicles are using an enhanced version of Tesla's more capable driver assistance system, which it calls Full Self-Driving.

Update: This story has been updated to include the amount of compensatory damages in the total.

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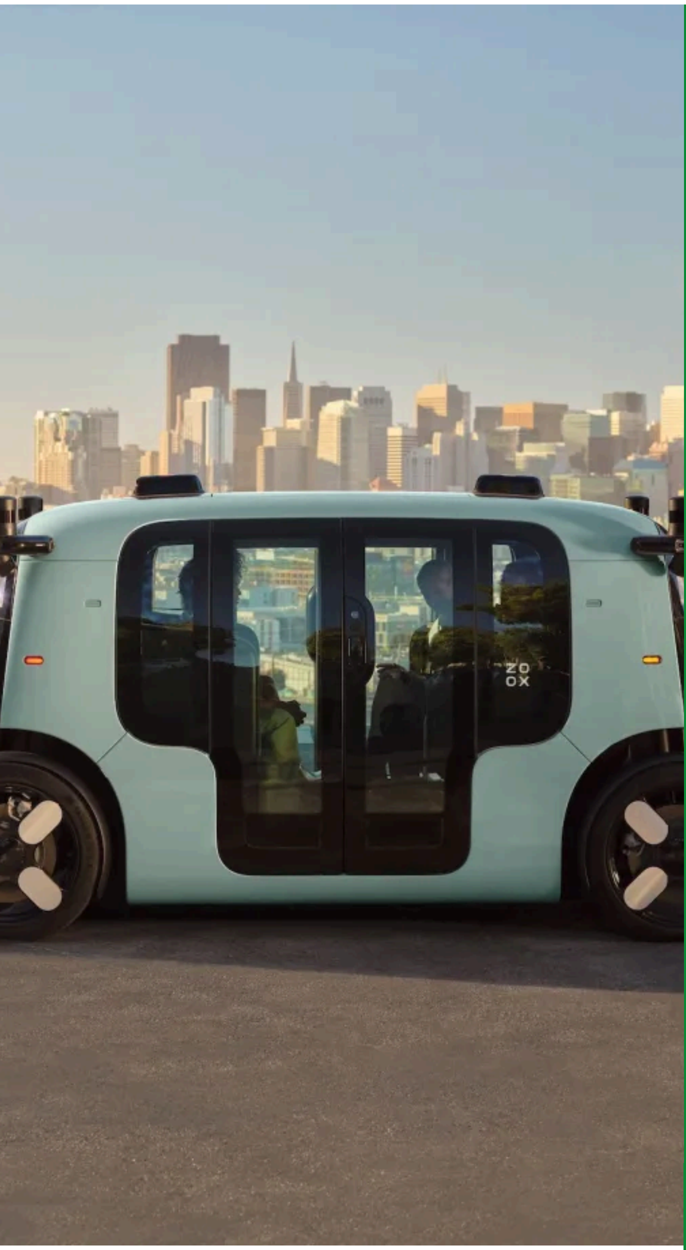

IMAGE CREDITS: ZOOX

TRANSPORTATION

Federal regulators give Zoox an exemption for its custom-built robotaxis

Kirsten Korosec — 12:02 PM PDT · August 6, 2025

The National Highway Traffic Safety Administration has given Zoox an exemption to demonstrate its custom-built robotaxis on public roads and closed a related investigation into whether the Amazon-owned company had sidestepped federal regulations.

The decision, which was announced Wednesday, clears up a long-standing debate over whether

other traditional controls, on public roads near its Foster City, California headquarters. The company has since expanded its testing footprint to [Las Vegas and San Francisco](#).

Zoox does not operate a commercial service yet. However, in San Francisco it has opened its robotaxis up to employees and hosted family and friends. Earlier this year, the company launched an Zoox Explorer program, aimed at early public riders, in Las Vegas.

For now, the exemption allows Zoox to demonstrate the robotaxis, not operate them commercially.

NHTSA's announcement is connected to its [new national framework](#), which the agency argues will make it easier for companies to deploy autonomous vehicles without traditional manual driving controls — like steering wheels, pedals, and sideview mirrors — at scale.

The framework allows NHTSA to green-light the sale and commercialization of autonomous vehicles that are not compliant with federal safety standards due to a lack of manual controls.

The revised process involves an expedited application that allows companies like Zoox to receive exemptions for testing and demonstrations, and eventually, commercial operations. Zoox spokesperson Whitney Jencks said in an email that

Zoox is working in close cooperation with NHTSA on this process, beginning with the demonstration exemption and followed by the commercial exemption.

As part of the agreement, NHTSA has closed its investigation into Zoox's self-certification of its AVs. Zoox has agreed to remove or cover all statements that its purpose-built vehicles comply with applicable Federal Motor Vehicle Safety Standards.

Topics: autonomous vehicles Transportation zoox

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IMAGE CREDITS: JEH AEROSPACE

TRANSPORTATION

Jeh Aerospace nets $11M to scale the commercial aircraft supply chain in India

Jagmeet Singh — 5:30 PM PDT · August 4, 2025

Indian startup Jeh Aerospace founders Vishal Sanghavi and Venkatesh Mudragalla have had a front-row seat to the commercial aircraft sector and its growing production bottleneck.

The two former Tata Group executives spent close to two decades in different positions at the company and worked on projects that included participation from global aerospace companies, including Boeing, Sikorsky, and Lockheed Martin.

Now, armed with $11 million in Series A funding, the pair are working to ease global supply chain bottlenecks by scaling the production of metallic

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components for aero engines and aerostructures, which it then sells to U.S.-based Tier 1 suppliers that work with commercial aircraft manufacturers such as Airbus and Boeing.

And they plan to help India become a destination for aerospace component manufacturing in the process.

“At Tatas, we unlocked India’s potential for these large OEMs, Boeing, Airbus, Sikorsky, and GE [General Electric], but we wanted Jeh Aerospace to unlock India’s potential for the large Tier 1 and Tier 2 manufacturers in the supply chain,” said Sanghavi, who is also CEO at Jeh.

JEH AEROSPACE CO-FOUNDERS VENKATESH MUDRAGALLA (LEFT) AND VISHAL SANGHAVI (RIGHT).

IMAGE CREDITS:JEH AEROSPACE

Jeh Aerospace, which is headquartered in Atlanta to better access its U.S. customer base, has a 60,000-square-foot software-based, precision manufacturing facility in the southern Indian city of Hyderabad. The 3-year-old startup has combined precision machinery, robotics, and IoT devices to slash product introduction lead times from the industry’s traditional 15-week timeline to 15 days.

Jeh Aerospace’s software-defined manufacturing approach helps bring predictability and dynamic

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scheduling to allow offering a consistent supply to customers with no compromises on quality, Sanghavi said.

And it seems VCs and strategic investors are interested in Jeh Aerospace's pitch.

The Series A round was led by Elevation Capital, with participation from General Catalyst. With the infusion of the new capital, Jeh Aerospace has raised about $15 million in total from institutional venture capital firms. The VC fresh funding comes less than a month after the startup received an undisclosed strategic investment from IndiGo Ventures, a corporate venture capital arm of Indian carrier IndiGo.

Ashray Iyengar, principal at Elevation Capital, said the company "built a truly differentiated approach to aerospace manufacturing."

Aircraft production bottleneck

Global air traffic demand rose 10.4% year-over-year in 2024, surpassing 2019 levels by 3.8%, per the International Air Transport Association data released earlier this year.

The rebound has spurred airlines to expand fleets, pushing up orders even as the industry grapples with talent and production bottlenecks, as Deloitte notes in a recent report. Tier 1 suppliers are facing extended lead times as the commercial aircraft backlog reaches a record of nearly 15,700 units, according to McKinsey.

Jeh Aerospace's founders believe using technology to scale production of metallic components for aero engines and aerostructures will unplug that bottleneck. That premise has shaped how Sanghavi, the former chief operating officer at Tata Boeing Aerospace, and Mudragalla have built its 100-person workforce, team of advisers, and business model.

IMAGE CREDITS:MCKINSEY AEROSPACE & DEFENSE PRACTICE

Instead of working directly with OEMs like Airbus and Boeing, which make 30% of commercial aircraft, Jeh Aerospace deliberately decided to tap Tier 1 and Tier 2 manufacturers, Sanghavi told TechCrunch, adding this group makes 60% to 70% of aircraft.

The startup currently has half a dozen paying customers, including Vermont-based GS Precision and Ohio-headquartered RH Aero. Sanghavi said each of these customers is a "high dollar, high ARR customer," and they have the potential to become large accounts in the next one to two years.

"What we believe is that to work with lesser, but better customers, not to have a transactional relationship, but a far deeper and meaningful relationship. So, we are also very, very focused on not having too many customers," he said. "The business doesn't need too many customers because you can really scale with few customers very fast and very quickly."

The company has also assembled an advisory team with deep ties to commercial aircraft OEMS. The startup counts former Boeing India president Pratyush (Prat) Kumar and former Airbus India CEO and managing director Dwaraka Srinivasan among its early advisers and backers.

Jeh Aerospace has made notable manufacturing and financial progress in its short life.

Since its $2.75 million seed round in January last year, Jeh Aerospace says it has delivered more than 100,000 flight-critical components and tools on time. The startup has also established a machine capacity exceeding 250,000 hours annually.

In the last financial year, the startup reached $6 million in annualized recurring revenue (ARR) and achieved profitability after taxes. Sanghavi told TechCrunch that it projects a 3x to 4x increase in its ARR this year and also boasts an order book worth $100 million.

JEH AEROSPACE'S FACILITY INCLUDES A CENTER OF AEROSPACE SKILL FOR TALENT TRAINING.

IMAGE CREDITS:JEH AEROSPACE

The company plans to use the new $11 million in capital to scale its manufacturing and inspection capabilities by investing in next-generation digital production technologies, Sanghavi said.

The Jeh Aerospace co-founders see an opportunity to bring more local manufacturing to India and strengthen the country's position on the global aerospace map, much like its recent emergence as a hub for iPhone production.

India already plays a growing role in aerospace manufacturing, with Airbus sourcing $1.4 billion worth of components annually from the country and targeting $2 billion by 2030. Boeing, for its part, is aiming for a $1.3 billion annual spend and announced its plans to invest $200 million in a new engineering and technology center in Bengaluru in 2023. Still, the South Asian nation has yet to achieve large-scale success in aerospace component manufacturing — a gap companies like Jeh Aerospace are hoping to fill.

Although few Indian startups operate in aerospace component manufacturing, the sector includes players like JJG Aero, which appears to be a peer to Jeh Aerospace based on industry positioning. Sanghavi declined to comment specifically on JJG and noted that his startup sees its primary competition among U.S.-based tier-2 suppliers.

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